OFFICIAL PARTICIPANT RULEBOOK

THE HIDDEN KEY

Six days. One cryptographic repository.

Dive into the source. Decode the mystery. Claim First Blood.

YOUR MISSION • NO PRIOR REGISTRATION REQUIRED

Investigate the challenge codebase crafted by **APPISTRY (App Development Club, STC IIT Patna Hybrid)**. There is **no prior registration**—simply dive in, examine clues published on the live stage, deduce the 3-part passphrase, run the offline terminal unlock utility, and submit your discovered keyword at `/submit` to secure your rank.

EVENT TIMELINE
3 – 8 NOV
2026 • 6-DAY CHALLENGE

FIRST BLOOD BOUNTY
HALL OF FAME
TROPHY & SPECIAL AWARD

TOP 10 SPOTLIGHT
STC INSTAGRAM
NAME & PHOTO SHOUTOUT

DIRECT SUBMISSION ENTRY • OFFICIAL @IITP.AC.IN • 3 TO 8 NOVEMBER 2026

github.com/ravi-c029/appistry-the-hidden-key

THE CASE & YOUR ROLE

The Investigation

Understand the case. Follow the evidence. Compete independently.

01 What is The Hidden Key?

THE HIDDEN KEY is a six-day online cryptographic mystery hunt running from **3 November to 8 November 2026**, hosted by **APPISTRY (App Development Club, STC IIT Patna Hybrid)**. There is no prior registration needed—participants enter their name and official `@iitp.ac.in` credentials directly when submitting their discovered keyword. The objective is to connect clues, deduce the 3-part passphrase, execute the offline unlock CLI, and register an authentic keyword on the live server.

02 How the investigation works

- **Event Duration:** Challenge officially commences on **3 November 2026** and concludes on **8 November 2026 (23:59 IST)**.
- **Clues Released Progressively:** Riddles and cryptographic clues are published on the live stage without requiring code updates.
- **Three-Part Mystery Passphrase:** The solution connects technical club identity, regional legacy, and the hybrid future.
- **Offline Terminal Decryption:** Participants clone the codebase and execute `npm run unlock`. The CLI derives an AES-256-GCM key using the Scrypt KDF to authenticate and decrypt the sealed artifact locally.
- **Instant Atomic Ranking:** Submitting the revealed keyword on the web portal registers an atomic server timestamp, locking your official rank.

☀️ Top 10 Social Media Spotlight Announcement

The **Top 10 fastest participants** who discover and submit the cryptographically correct secret keyword will be featured across the official **STC IIT Patna Hybrid Instagram and social media handles** with their photo, rank, and shoutout (published with their prior consent).

03 Participation rules

By participating, you agree to the rules below. They keep the mystery hunt fair, safe, and enjoyable for all IIT Patna students:

- **Direct Submission Entry:** No advance sign-up is required. Participant details and authentication occur directly at the time of final keyword submission.
- **Official @iitp.ac.in Credentials:** Participation is strictly limited to verified students of IIT Patna using their official college email.
- **Individual Entry:** Each participant competes independently. Team submissions, shared accounts, and proxy submissions are prohibited.
- **Single Submission:** Each participant is allowed exactly **one verified submission**. Double-check your keyword before submitting.
- **Rate-Limiting Protection:** The portal enforces a 20 submissions/minute rate limit. Automated script hammering will trigger automatic IP blacklisting.
- **Keep Answers Private:** Do not share decrypted keys, unreleased clues, or solution screenshots with other participants while the event is live.

TOOLS & FAIR PLAY

Investigate Responsibly

Use developer tools thoughtfully and stay within the official challenge environment.

04 AI and Developer Tools

AI tools are permitted as assistants

You may use LLMs such as ChatGPT, Claude, and Gemini, alongside Git terminal commands, Node.js scripts, and browser developer tools to inspect and analyze the materials. However, you remain entirely responsible for the final answer.

- **Cryptographic Ground Truth:** All answers must pass authentic AES-256-GCM authenticated tag verification. AI hallucinations will fail Scrypt key derivation.
- **Do Not Fabricate Keys:** Submitting random or speculative guesses wastes your single official submission opportunity.
- **Zero Points for Prompts:** Evaluation is strictly binary—either the secret keyword is cryptographically authentic, or it is not.
- **Finalist Verification:** Organizers reserve the right to request finalists to explain their investigative trail and deduction methodology.

05 Safety and permitted scope

- **Permitted Target:** Investigate only the repository code (`github.com/ravi-c029/appistry-the-hidden-key`) and the official live web application.
- **No Infrastructure Attacks:** Do not attack, port scan, overload, or attempt denial-of-service (DoS/DDoS) attacks against the Vercel hosting platform, submission API endpoints, or database clusters.
- **Offline Execution:** Run the `npm run unlock` CLI on your local development machine. It functions 100% offline and requires no internet calls.
- **Privacy & Respect:** Do not access, collect, or publish fellow participants' email addresses or personal information.

Immediate Disqualification Grounds

Automated brute-forcing of submission endpoints, impersonating another IIT Patna student, sharing solution keys in WhatsApp/Discord groups, or interfering with event services will result in immediate permanent disqualification.

SUBMISSIONS & WINNERS

Make Your Key Count

Accurate key verification. Microsecond timestamps. Permanent honor.

06 Honor & Bounty Structure

Timeliness, cryptographic accuracy, and server verification determine your standing on the official board.

CATEGORY	WHAT IS EVALUATED	HONOR & RECOGNITION
First Blood Champion	1st participant with valid verified submission on server	Trophy + STC Insta Feature + Headline
Top 10 Finishers	Top 10 fastest valid submissions by atomic server timestamp	STC Insta Spotlight (Photo + Rank) + Cert
Verified Solvers	All valid @iitp.ac.in submissions received by 8 Nov 23:59	Official Digital Certificate
LIVE DATES	3 Nov 2026 (00:00 IST) to 8 Nov 2026 (23:59 IST)	6-Day Window

07 How rankings are determined & Social Media Feature

- **Atomic Server Timestamps:** Rankings are ordered strictly by the atomic UTC timestamp recorded by the production database when your submission passes verification.
- **No Tie-Breakers Required:** High-precision server timestamps eliminate ties. Every microsecond counts.
- **Social Media Spotlight (Instagram & Channels):** The **Top 10 fastest and correct participants** will be celebrated on the official **STC IIT Patna Hybrid Instagram** handle and council media channels with their name, rank, and photo (published strictly with their consent).
- **Official Winner Announcement:** Final verified standings and certificates will be distributed between **9 and 10 November 2026**.

08 Submitting your secret keyword

- **Submission Portal:** Navigate to `/submit` on the live web portal.
- **Direct Data Collection:** Enter your Full Name, official `@iitp.ac.in` email, and discovered keyword.
- **Case Sensitivity:** The secret keyword is case-sensitive and must match the terminal unlock output exactly.
- **Confirmation Receipt:** Upon successful submission, an on-screen confirmation badge and recorded timestamp will be displayed.

> **Before you submit**
> Ensure that your secret keyword was confirmed with "ACCESS GRANTED" by the offline CLI utility before submitting. Each participant has only 1 official submission.